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The Image of Ascent in the Liturgical Prayers of the Feast of Ascension in the Byzantine and Syro-Malankara Liturgy.

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Introduction

Feast and festivals are old as mankind.[1] The feasts of our Lord have the most prominence than any other feasts.[2] The mysteries of Jesus are expressed through images. In this paper, the image of Ascent in the liturgical prayers of the Feast of Ascension in the Byzantine and Syro-Malankara liturgical traditions will be presented. Here, we shall make an effort to study the image of Ascent considering the prayers of the Feast of Ascension from the Biblical and Patristic perspectives.

The following topics are discussed here.1) The History of the Feast of Ascension, 2) The Image of Ascent and its Biblical Background, 3) The Image of Ascent and Decent in Jesus, 3.1) The Ascent of Jesus, 3.1.1) Ascent of Jesus and Elijah, 3.2) Jesus' Ascent as His glorification, 3.3) Jesus' Ascent and Adam's Glorification, 3.4) The Ascent of Jesus and Descent of the Holy Spirit, 3.5) Ascent of Jesus and the Assurance of His second coming.

1 History of the Feast of Ascension.

The feast of the Ascension is one of the prominent feasts. In the most ancient times, the feast of Ascension and Easter celebrated were together. The fiftieth day after Easter was significant ending of the season, marked by with the commemoration of the decent of the Holy Spirit upon the church.[3] Reports of Eusebius of Caesarea (332)[4] and the Egeria (383) gives some information about the celebration of this feast. According to Egeria's report, in the morning a service was held related to the outpouring of the spirit and in the celebration on the Mount Olives recalled the Ascension of the lord held at the afternoon one the same day.[5] Hence, there was an emergence of the importance of Spirit in the life of the church. And in the Acts 1:3, it is clearly presented in the following quote, 'appearing to them during forty days. Later in the beginning of the Fourth Century, the development of the division of the unique feasts such as "Easter day is connected with the Resurrection, the fortieth day with the Ascension, the fiftieth with the outpouring of the Spirit." [6] Hence it is clear that, the Church

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[1] A. ADAM, *The liturgical year*, 23.

[2] *Sacrosanctum Concilium*, "The Second Vatican Council", Nos: 102-108.

[3] A. KAKKANATT, *Christological Catechesis of the* liturgy: *A study on the Great Feasts of our Lord in the Malankara Church,* 53.

[4] Cfr. "All these events occurred during a most important festival, I mean the august and holy solemnity of Pentecost, which is distinguished by a period of seven weeks, and sealed with that one day on which the holy Scriptures attest, the ascension of our common Saviour into heaven, and the descent of the Holy Spirit among men." In EUSEBIUS PAMPHILIUS*: Church History: Life of Constantine the Great, and Orations in Praise of Constantine, NPNF*, 2-01,557.

[5] EGERIA: *Diary of a Pilgrimage*,118-119.

[6] J. DANIELOU, S. J, *The Bible and the liturgy,* 318.

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celebrated the feast of the Ascension on the fortieth day of Easter from the fourth century onwards.

2 The Image of Ascent and its Biblical Background.

The image of Ascent could also be seen in the celestial sacred and Uranian Gods from the Greek mythology.

> There dwell the gods; there a few privileged mortals make their way by rites of ascent; there, in the conception of certain religions, mount the souls of the dead. The "most high" is a dimension inaccessible to man as man; it belongs to superhuman forces and beings. He who ascends by mounting the steps of a sanctuary or the ritual ladder that leads to the sky ceases to be a man; in one way or another, he shares in the divine condition.[7]

Here, it is clear that the one having the capacity to ascend to heaven is considered to be linked with the divine realities.

In the Biblical tradition, the image of Ascent is almost always connected with the divine reality. In the Bible Ascent is connected with mountains. This upward movement is for the communication with the divine reality. Moses ascended to the mountain. There he had the communication with God (Ex:19,24). I kings 18:42 says, "And Elijah went up to mount Carmel." Then 2 kings 2:11 we read "As they (Elijah and Elisha) continued walking and talking, a chariot of fire and horse of fire separated the two of them, and Elijah ascended in a whirlwind into heaven." And Zech 14: 4-9 also for tells the glorification of the Lord as King: "On that day his feet shall stand on the Mount of Olives, which lies before Jerusalem on the east …. And the Lord will become king over all the earth; on that day the Lord will be one and his name one." In Ps 24: 3 we read "who shall ascend the hill of the Lord? And who shall stand in his holy place." Hence, we could say that the image of ascend is related to the mountains, where one can encounter the divine. Hence, Ascending could be considered as a corporeal image of a movement with the intent of having an experience of the divine.

In the New Testament, this image of Ascent could also be found in various instances. Regarding Jesus' baptism, it is written that He came up from the water (Mt 3:16). Jesus ascends or climbs to mountain to teach, especially the beatitude (Mt 5: 1). The imagery of Ascent is portrayed when He went up to the mountain for prayer (Mt 14:23). In the transfiguration narrative also, we find Jesus on the mountain. Luke says, "Now about eight days after Jesus took with him Peter and John and James and went up to mountain to pray." (Lk 9:28). Finally, the Ascension of Jesus into Heaven after resurrection is centered on mountain and which is from mount of olive. Both liturgical traditions clearly express that He ascended from the mount olive.

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[7] M.ELIADE, *The Significance of religious myth, and ritual within life and culture*, Trans., W. R. TRASK, 118- 119.

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> *Jesus the giver of life, took with him those whom he loved, went up the Mount of Olives, blessed them and, borne by cloud, reached the bosom of the Father, whom he had never left.* (BYZ[8], Ascension, Orthros, Theotokìon, 451.)
>
> *Today Christ God ascends to His father from the mount of olives with glory.* (SMC[9], Ascension, Vespro, Response, 150).

Here, we can understand that the Ascent is an upward movement associated with the divine reality. We find this image in both Old Testament and New Testament. This image of Ascent is both a corporeal movement. We could chart the life of Jesus within a frame of movement. It can be considered that Jesus' life is like a movement. The movement of Jesus' life begins with His descent from heaven and concludes with His Ascension.

3 The images of Ascent and Descent in Jesus.

A clear foundation of the image of ascent and descent of Jesus is seen in the Bible. In John's Gospel it is very clear, "No one has ascended into heaven except the one who descended from heaven, the son of Man (Jn 3: 13)." Paul says in Eph 4:10, "He who has descended is the same one who ascended far above all the heavens." According to the teaching of the church fathers, the most remarkable understanding of the descent and ascent of Jesus is that Jesus' descent occurred when he assumed human nature in the Incarnation. And His ascent means the ascension of human and divine Jesus to the right hand of the father, after his resurrection. [10] In Phil 2:6, says "He emptied himself, taking the form of a salve, being born in human likeness." Here the womb of blessed Mary was the vehicle for Him for His descent into the world. St. Ephrem clearly mentions the same when he wrote, "The power of the Father, compelled by his love, descended and dwelt in virgin womb."[11] Cyril of Jerusalem says, "In Bethlehem He descended from heaven; from the mount olives He ascended into heaven."[12] Tertullian also says "The same son who descended also ascends to heaven."[13] Saint Augustine conveys the same message when he speaks of the Ascension of Jesus. He says that "He has ascended. Who? He who descended."[14] We can see this image in the prayers of feast of Ascension in the both liturgical traditions.

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[8] Cfr. Here onwards in this paper I am using BYZ as for Byzantine Tradition

[9] Cfr. Here on onwards in this paper I am using SML as for Syro-Malankara Liturgy.

[10] K. M. KAPIC, W.V. LUGT, «The ascension of Jesus and the descent of the Holy Spirit in patristic perspective: a theological reading », in *Evangelical Quarterly: An International Review of Bible and Theology*,24.

[11] S. BROCK, *The Luminous Eye*, 54.

[12] K. M. KAPIC, W.V. LUGT, «The ascension of Jesus and the descent of the Holy Spirit in patristic perspective: a theological reading », in *Evangelical Quarterly: An International Review of Bible and Theology*, 26.

[13] T.C. ODEN, C.A HALL, ed., *Ancient Christian Commentary of Scripture*, *New Testament II*, *Mark,*254.

[14] AUGUSTINUS, Sermo 261 (CPL 284), in SAINT AUGUSTINE. *Sermons on the liturgical Season*, English Trans., M.S MULDOWNEY, 379.

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> *Now that you have ascended to the heavens, from which you had descended.* (BYZ, Ascension, *Vespro*, Tone 1, 444.)
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> *He descended in order to ascend, as Paul has written. He who was wrapped in strips of cloth dwells in highest heaven…"* (SML, Ascension, Night prayers, Second hour,162)

3.1 The Ascent of Jesus

The scriptures refer to Jesus' Ascension. The psalmist foretold it in Ps 24 :7- (Ps 23:7-LXX) "Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O ancient doors! that the king of glory may come in." Justin says that these words were fulfilled in the Ascension of Jesus into heaven.[15] Hippolytus interprets these words to mean that Jesus comes to the heavenly gates accompanied by the angles, but the gates of heaven were closed, for he appears to the powers of heaven as flesh ascending. Therefore, these words are said by the accompanying angels to the powers of heaven.[16] Origen conveys the same message. He says that these words are uttered by those escorting Him, to those who stationed at the gates of heaven.[17] We can find the same psalms used in the vespro of Ascension of the both liturgical traditions.[18] In Ps 68:18-19 (Ps 67: 18-19- LXX) we can read: "You ascended the high mount, leading captives in your train and receiving gifts from people, even from those who rebel against the Lord God's abiding there." Hence, the prophesies about the ascension of Jesus have fulfilled on the Ascension Day. This message about the image of Ascent is also very clear in the prayers of two liturgical traditions.

> *David the inspired cries out with all clarity in his psalms. The Lord has ascended to the heavens amid acclamations and the echoing of trumpets, and has reached his father, the source of light. O Lord, having renewed by your passion and resurrection the world aged by I tan sins, you ascended to the heavens, borne by a cloud: glory to your glory* (BYZ, Ascension, Orthros, tone 4, 448)
>
> *Today the oracles of the prophets are fulfilled, the oracles of Moses the divine prophet who said: I saw the lord sitting upon a throne and beneath him there was it were a paved work of sapphire. And David, the king and prophet and harp of the lord who cried out in spirit: You have gone up on high. You have led away captives. You have given to men.* (SML, Feast of Ascension, Sedro, Evening prayer, 151)

In this Ascension narrative, we can observe that while seeing the Ascension of Jesus, the angles were amazed and did not recognize Him as He returned. Here, we see the fulfillment of Ps 24:8 (Ps 23:8, LXX) "Who is the king of glory? The lord, strong and mighty, the lord mighty in battle." Gregory of Nazianzus

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[15] J. DANIELOU, S.J, *The Bible and the liturgy,* 303-304.
[16] C. A. BLAISING & C.S. HARDIN, ed., Ancient *Christian Commentary on Scripture, Old Testament VII, Psalms 1-50,* 188.
[17] Ibid, 190.
[18] BYZ: Ascensione, Vespro, Tono 2, 444, SMC: Ascension, Vespro, 164.

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comments about these words. He says that, Jesus bears up His body with him as a symbol of His passion, because when he came down to earth he did not have it. Hence, those who receive Him ask who the king of glory is.[19] Because Christ descended into the world without the knowledge of angelic powers of the intermediate of heavens, they did not recognize Him in His decent. [20]According to Justin even in the Ascent also they did not recognize Him, because of His human appearance which He was clothed.[21] St. Ambrose says, "The angels themselves also doubted when Christ rose again, in seeing that His flesh ascended to heaven."[22] Hence the mystery that was hidden during the Decent of Christ was manifested to the angles in the Ascent. These themes of amazement and hidden revelation appears first in the "*Ascension of Isaias"*[23]*:*

> He ascended into the second heaven, and He did not transform himself, but all the angels who were at the right hand and the left, and the throne which is in the midst of them, both adored Him and praised Him, and they said: How did our Lord escape us whilst descending and we perceived not.[24]

> *The hosts of angels, O Savior, seeing the mortal nature ascending united to you, unceasingly celebrated you, filled with awe. They were astonished The choirs of angels, O Christ, seeing you ascend with a body, and celebrated his holy Ascension* (BYZ, Ascension, Orthros, 449)

> *Our Saviour rose and ascended. He sat at the right of His Father. The heavenly companies marvel when they see Him with His body, and they ask each other, Who is He who comes from Edom. By His Ascension He gives joy to angels and men, and each order, according as it can, gives praise to Him for His humiliation by which it is exalted.* (SML, Feast of Ascension, Evening Prayer, Hymn,152)

> *God who was spoken of by the prophets and openly proclaimed by the apostles...It gives us happiness. You gave joy to those on earth by Your descent and gladness to those in heaven by Your Ascension. Hidden revealed. Today the wisdom of God which was hidden before, is finally revealed to the Holy Church. Today the doors of heaven lift up their heads that they may receive the King of glory, who is the Lord of glory and the God of strength.* (SMC, Feast of Ascension , Evening Prayers, 151)

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[19] C. A. BLAISING & C.S. HARDIN, *Ancient Christian Commentary on Scripture, Old Testament VII, Psalms 1-50*, 189.
[20] J. DANIELOU, S.J, *The Bible and the liturgy*, 303.
[21] Ibid, 304.
[22] Ibid, 306.
[23] Cfr.The Ascension of Isaiah, sometimes referred to as the Assumption of Isaiah, is one of the pseudepigrapha: a group of texts written under false names associated with biblical characters. The text is also referred to as the Martyrdom of Isaiah, the Testament of Hezekiah, or the Vision of Isaiah.in what is the ascension of Isaiah? See in https://www.gotquestions.org/Ascension-of-Isaiah.html.
[24] CHARLES, R.H, *The Ascension of Isaiah*: *translated from Ethiopic version, together with the new Greek fragment and the Latin versions and Latin translation*, *XI 25-26*, 79-80.

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Hence it is clear that, the Ascension of Jesus was the fulfillment of these prophesies and was foretold by the Psalmist. And it is the same God who descended in His Incarnation Ascended in His Ascension to Heaven. In His Ascension the mystery which was hidden during Incarnation was thereafter revealed to the angles.

3.1.1 Ascent of Jesus and Elijah

As regard the Ascent of Jesus, it is very relevant to see the difference between the Jesus's Ascent to heaven and of the Ascent of other humans which we find in the Bible as well. Regarding the Ascent of Jesus, we read: "While he had said this, as they were watching, He was lifted up, and a cloud took Him out of their sight." (Acts1:9) This Ascent is different from the ascent of Elijah in the O.T. "As they continued walking and talking, a chariot of fire and horse of fire separated the two of them, and Elijah ascended in a whirlwind into heaven." (2 king 2:11). According to Jacob of Serugh, Jesus was exalted not like Elijah because Elijah was not able to ascend by himself but means of a chariot, meaning only with the power of the Lord. Serugh continues by saying that our lord does not need any conveyance, for he ascended by His own power.[25] St. Chrysostom explains it with a question. He asks why a cloud to Jesus, and not fire, as in the case of Elijah? Because the cloud was a symbol of heaven. He quotes Ps 103: 3, where we can read "you make the clouds your chariot." He also connects Is 19: 1 where we read "the lord is riding on a swift cloud". [26] Hence, we can conclude that Jesus ascended into heaven with His divine power and cloud was His vehicle. And human beings always need Divine help to ascend to heaven. And this theme is clearly emphasized in the prayers of both traditions.

> *O thou who art kindled on a bright cloud, and hast saved the world, blessed art thou, O God, of our fathers* (BYZ, Ascension, Orthros, Tropari, 455)
>
> *The cloud approaches and carries away the Firstborn who came forth from Mary.* (SML, Ascension of our lord, Night vigil, Hymns, 159)

3.2 Jesus' Ascent as His Glorification

This is one of the main themes when we consider the image of Ascent of Jesus. "So, then the Lord Jesus, after he has spoken to them, was taken up into heaven and sat down at the right hand of God." (Mk 16: 19). This signifies the glorification of Christ in His Ascent when He sits at the right hand of the father. Tertullian connected this image with the vision of St. Stephen at his martyrdom by stoning, still sitting at the right hand of God. Here he connects the words from

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[25] T. KOLLAMPARAMBIL, *Salvation in Christ According to Jacob of* Serugh: *An Exegetico-theological Study on the Homilies of Jacob of Serugh on the Feasts of our Lord*, 198.
[26] F. MARTIN, ed., *Ancient Christian Commentary of Scripture: New Testament V, Acts*, 10-11.

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Ps 110:1(Ps 109:1, LXX), where it can be seen "Sits at my right hand until I make your enemies your footstool." [27] Cyril of Jerusalem comments about the psalm. He says that, "He who was crucified on this very Golgotha ascended to heaven from the Mount of Olives, when his father called him saying sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool."[28] Irenaeus also comments that, in seeing Him the lower angles cried out to those and they said open your gates, be raised, eternal doors, and the king of glory will make His entrance because He is the lord strong and mighty and it is He, the king of glory.[29] Because He is sitting there as a victorious king because He had the victory over the death. With which He saved the humankind. Because He has fulfilled the whole salvific economy. About this Nasrai writes:

> The master finished (his) apt instructions to his disciples and started to journey on a new road to the height (of heaven). He fulfilled the will of his Sender by (his) redemption of men and accomplished, (his) active work (of salvation) for the universe. He achieved (his) victory in the sight of spiritual and corporeal beings.[30]

And when we consider the glorification of Jesus, Augustine says there are two glorifications in the earthly life of Jesus. One is that He rose from the dead on the third day. The other is that He ascended into heaven before the eyes of His disciple.[31] And he says that, while sitting in Heaven He is Omnipresent. That is "God and man in Him are one person and both are one in Jesus Christ who is everywhere as God."[32] Here it very clear that in His ascent to heaven He was welcomed and glorified by the heavenly realities as the King of Glory and Savior of the world. He sits at the right hand of the His father as Omnipresent. This image is clearly emphasized in the prayers of the both liturgical traditions.

> *To the Christ who ascends gloriously on the shoulders of the Cherubim, and with him makes us also sit at the right hand of the Father, let us sing, peoples all, a song of victory, for he has made himself glorious.* (BYZ, Orthros, Tropari, 448.)
>
> *Our Saviour rose and ascended. He sat at the right of His Father. The heavenly companies marvel when they see Him with His body, and they ask each other,*

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[27] T. C. ODEN & C.A. HALL, ed., *Ancient Christian Commentary of Scripture*, *New Testament II, Mark*, 254.
[28] Q. F. WESSELSCHMIDT, ed., *Ancient Christian Commentary on Scripture, Old Testament, Psalms II, 51-150*,262.
[29] J. DANIELOU, S.J, *The Bible and the liturgy*, 304.
[30] A. KAKKANATT, *Christological Catechesis of the Liturgy: A study on the Great Feasts of our lord in the Malankara Church*,203.
[31] AUGUSTINUS, Sermo 261 (CPL 284), in English Trans., M.S. MULDOWNEY, *Saint Augustine. Sermons on the liturgical Seasons*, 415.
[32] T. C. ODEN & C.A. HALL, ed., Ancient *Christian Commentary on Scripture, New Testament II, Mark*, 255.

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> *"Who is He who comes from Edom°. And why are His clothes stained red like those of one who has trodden a winepress? His Ascension gives us Joy. By His Ascension He gives joy to angels and men, and each order, according as it can, gives praise to Him for His humiliation by which it is exalted.* (SML, Feast of Ascension, Evening Prayers, 153)

> *On the day of your Holy Ascension, O Son of God, heaven and _earth rejoice in You with the whole the Creation. And the Church also rejoices and sings praise to You O Good One, who saved her by Your Cross the Watch tears in heaven cry out _to You, on the day of_ Your Ascension: _ "You are holy King Christ Saviour of the world.* (SMC, Hymn, Night prayers, 162.)

3.3 Jesus' Ascent and Adam's Glorification

The glorification of Adam who represents the humanity is clearly emphasized in the prayers of Ascension Day. For its Biblical foundation, St. Paul teaches about the same in his letter to Ephesians (2:4-6) reminds us that, "God, who is rich in mercy, out of great love he loved us even when we were dead through our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ- by grace you have been saved- and raised us up with him and seated us with Him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus." Hence, the Ascent of Christ paved way for the glorification of Adam. Through His Ascension He saves us forever. Also, through the Incarnation, Death, and Resurrection and Ascension, He reinstated humanity into the position which was once lost by Adam. The position which was lost due to sin of the first Adam was restored by Jesus, the second Adam.[33] St. Ephrem clearly emphasized this in his hymns on Resurrection. He says "His birth gives us purification, His baptism gives us forgiveness, His death is life for us, His Ascension is our exaltation. How we should thank him."[34] Narsai also commented about this exultated nature of humanity in his homily on Ascension. For him, the deification and rising up the human nature with Christ's Ascension into heaven favorite images.[35] Jacob of Serugh also comments on the restoration of humanity into His father's side through His Ascension and made them children of His father. He says:

> He entered through the ear, came out from the womb and became a babe and He starched out His hand to the hole of Asp, the corrupter; and made return Adam who has been bitten was worn out there. He became embodied that He might become capable of suffering and He carried away the iniquity of the world by

[33] A.J. NAIDU, «The First Adam-Second Adam Typology in John Chrysostom and Cyril of Alexandria», in *Perichoresis,* Vol 12, Issue 2, 159.
[34] S. BROCK; Ed., *The Harp of the Spirit*: *Twelve Poems of St. Ephrem*, O 29.
[35] NARSAI, "Homily on Ascension" in *Patrologia Orientalies,* Vol 40, 167.1903 in A. KAKKANATT, *Christological Catechesis of the Liturgy: A study on the Great Feasts of our lord in the Malankara Church*, 57.

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> the sufferings of His crucifixion. He brought freedom for the race that was slaved and He made them ascend until they became sons His father.[36]

He continues by saying that Heaven rejoiced because the lord who is the lord of heights came solemnly to her and reconciled heaven and earth, which were at enmity. He freed Adam from Sheol.[37] Thus He opened the way to heaven. This theme is clearly emphasized in the liturgical prayers of both traditions.

> *Thou hast raised up, O Christ, human nature that had fallen into corruption, Thou hast carried it on high by Thy ascension, and together with Thee Thou hast glorified us.* (BYZ, Ascension Orthros, Tropari, 449.)

> *We offer You thanksgiving, adoration and praise for Your Ascension, You, the Word, Uniquely Beloved Son, God, Saviour of the World, who ascended the throne of Your Majesty in the flesh making the race of Adam to ascend with You. On the day of Your Ascension those above and those below cry to You, "Holy, Holy, Holy are You, halleluiah, in heaven and on earth*. (SML, Ascension, Night Vigil- II hour, 162,)

> *When you thus ascended to heaven, you opened the gates which Adam, our first father had closed in our face by his disobedience…. You made us return to our ancient inheritance and you made us sit at the right hand of Your father.* (SMC, Ascension, Vespro, Sedro, 165)

We conclude by mentioning that through His Ascension the race of Adam was taken back to His father's side. He reconciled Heaven and Earth and opened the way to Heaven. His Ascent was therefore His own Glorification as God as well as the glorification of the children of Adam. Hence this feast invites the faithful to ascend our hearts with Him while we celebrate and meditate on these mysteries on this feast of Ascension.

3.4 Ascent of Jesus and Descent of the Holy Spirit

In Jn 7: 37-39, Jesus connected the coming of the Holy spirit with regard to His glorification. "Now he said about the spirit, which believers in him were to receive; for as yet there was no spirit, because Jesus was not yet glorified." We have seen that glorification of Jesus includes His resurrection from the dead and His ascension of to heaven. In Acts 1: 7-8 "He replied, it is not for you to know the times or periods that the Father has set by his own authority. But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem." Here Jesus promises His disciples the arrival of the Holy Spirit after His Ascension. Here the entry of Jesus into His glory, that is, His ascent to the Father and the descent of the Holy Spirit constitutes two

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[36] T. KOLLAMPARAMBIL, *Salvation in Christ According to Jacob of* Serugh: *An Exegetico-theological Study on the Homilies of Jacob of Serugh on the Feasts of our Lord*, 195-196.
[37] Ibid, 199.

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complementary aspects of a single event of Salvation. John Chrysostom comments on this theme in his homilies on Ascension. He says, "Heaven has the holy body and the earth received the Holy Spirit."[38] Irenaeus explained that our ascent starts with Jesus' own Ascension and the sending of the Holy Spirit. We ascend through the spirit to the Son, and through the son to the father.[39] Augustine also commented on the purpose of the arrival of Holy Spirit after the Ascension of Jesus. He says Jesus intended to send the Holy Spirit after ten days and then the Holy Spirit would fill them which the spiritual love. And which will help them to understand Christ was the word of God, through whom all things were made.[40] Thus, we could conclude that there is a connection between Jesus' ascent and descent of the Holy Spirit. Holy Spirit became the helper of the Humanity, just as Jesus had told in his disciples during his earthly life. This image is clearly emphasized in the prayers of the both liturgical traditions.

> *You have ascended in glory, O King of angels, to send us the Paraclete from near the Father. Therefore we cry out: Glory, O Christ, to your power, O Lord.* (BYZ, Ascension, Orthros, Tropari, 450)
>
> *You ascended and went to heaven from where You descended. You would not leave us bereft like orphans, Lord of all. The Holy Spirt would come and give us peace by His descent and He would teach and make manifest to the sons of men the wonderful works of Your greatness, O Lover of Humankind.* (SML, Ascension, Night Vigil I hour, 158)

3.5 Ascent of Jesus and the Assurance of His second coming

The assurance of Jesus' second coming of Jesus very evident in the Ascension episode. This theme is very clear in In Acts 1: 10-11: "While he was going and they were gazing up toward heaven, suddenly two men in white robes stood by them. They said …this Jesus, who has been taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you so him go into heaven." St. Chrysostom says that he will come in the same way upon a cloud.[41] St. Augustine says Jesus will come in the same way and that he will be the One was pierced. Here he is referring to Jn: 19:37 "They will look on the one whom they have pierced." This is a quotation from Zech: 12:10 "they look on the one whom they have pierced." Augustine continues, saying that in His second coming Jesus will come to men as God-Man to make men like unto God. Jesus has ascended as Judge of Heaven,

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[38] K. M. KAPIC, W.V. LUGT, «The ascension of Jesus and the descent of the Holy Spirit in patristic perspective: a theological reading », in *Evangelical Quarterly: An International Review of Bible and Theology*, 29.
[39] Ibid, 31.
[40] AUGUSTINUS, Sermo 261 (CPL 284), in SAINT AUGUSTINE. *Sermons on the liturgical Season*, English Trans., M.S MULDOWNEY, 403.
[41] F. MARTIN, *Ancient Christian commentary of Scripture: New Testament V, Acts*, 11.

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there He revealed Himself as Herald of heaven.[42] This means He will come to the world as righteous judge. Hence, the participation in the liturgy prepares the faithful to wait for the second coming of Jesus. This this image also clearly highlighted in the prayers of the both liturgical traditions.

> *Ascending with the clouds of heaven, and leaving peace to those who remained on earth, you ascended and seated yourself at the right hand of the Father, as consubstantial with him and the Spirit: for you appeared in the flesh, but you underwent no change. Thus you await the term set for the end when you come to earth to judge the whole world. O Lord, righteous Judge, spare our souls, giving your servants remission of guilt.* (BYZ, Ascensione, Orthros, Kathisma. Tone 4, 450)

> *Today the angels make known to the apostles the Great Mystery of the second coming. He will manifest Himself to us in the body which He received from us. And all those who believe in Him will rejoice and sing praise*.(SML, Ascension, Evening Prayers, 150)

Conclusion

This paper presented and examined the image of the Ascent specifically with regard to the feast of Jesus' Ascension. The image of the Ascent was explored in depth from the Biblical and Patristic background, which mainly considered the liturgical prayers of the feast of Ascension of Jesus in the Byzantine and Syro-Malankara liturgical tradition.

The history of the celebration of the feast of Ascension was examined and reviewed. With the available evidence, it can be concluded that the Church started to celebrate the feast of Ascension on the fortieth day of Easter from the fourth century onwards. The image of Ascent and its Biblical foundation was showed and discussed. It presented that the image of Ascent is also found in Greek mythology that presented the human being to be elevated to a divine thing. The capacity to ascend to heaven is considered to be linked with the divine realities. Likewise in the Bible, both on Old Testament and New Testament the image of Ascent was a corporeal movement, often connected with the experiences on mountains. This divine experience is seen particularly in the Ascent of Jesus, which took place on the mount of Olives.

The image of Descent and Ascent permeates in the whole life of Jesus. The Ascent of Christ is the fulfillment of the Old Testament prophesies. The movement of the earthly life begins with a descent from Heaven and concludes with His Ascent into Heaven. In the case of Jesus, it is also a corporeal movement. In His descent, the womb of the Blessed Mother was His vehicle and, in His

[42] AUGUSTINUS, Sermo 261 (CPL 284), in SAINT AUGUSTINE. *Sermons on the liturgical Season*, English Trans., M.S MULDOWNEY, 409.

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Ascent, the cloud was His vehicle. The Ascent of Jesus was His own glorification as the king who sits at the right-side of the father as well as the glorification of the human race, that is represented by Adam. The connection between the Ascent of Christ with the Descent of the Holy Spirit and the second coming of Jesus were discussed too. All the New Testament authors are convinced that the entry of Jesus into His glory, which is His Ascent to the Father and the descent of the Holy Spirit constitute two complementary aspects of a single salvation event. Finally, the image of the Ascent spiritually leads the faithful to raise their life with the ascended Christ as they participate in the liturgical celebration on the feast of Ascension. This is because Ascension is understood as a movement, which is really a spiritual movement for the purpose of divine communication with God.

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